A sixth guess clears draw 1: $k^* \le 6$ at $\ell = 9$ on all four draws (m = 3)

Stage diagnostic (exact algebra), follow-up to dreg_guess_scaling_20261106; preregistered before any run. Every number is an unverified assertion [pcc:unverified].

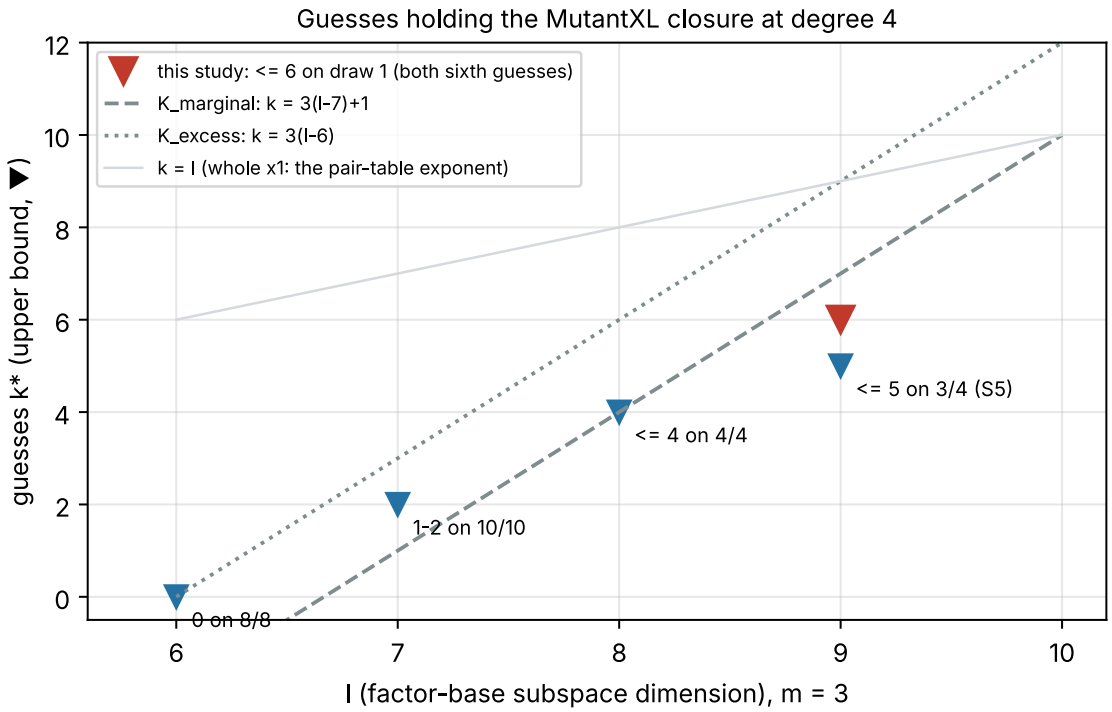

Figure 1: Guesses that hold the degree-4 MutantXL closure against ℓ (m = 3). Red: this study.

- **Identity control N** reproduces S5.d1.b28 exactly: saturated at degree 4, rank 188,151, unrefuted.
- **Arm I** (next invariant, s[6]): 8 of 8 corner branches refute at degree 4.
- **Arm E** (next e_1 coordinate): 8 of 8 corner branches refute at degree 4.
- **Reading:** $k^* \le 6$ on draw 1. With the parent study, $k^* \le 6$ at $\ell = 9$ on 4 of 4 draws, below `K_marginal`'s 7.
- **Limits:** this is still about ℓ guesses at constant degree, which is the pair-table exponent. It covers one cell at m = 3, does not touch m = 4, and moves no row.